

gbawriter V3.0

Full controls · Halim Jarrar

Create and edit TXT files on your Game Boy Advance. Save your writing directly to the SD card. Put TXT files in **/gbawriter** at the root of your SD card. Requires a compatible Supercard SD.

Hardware-unverified build: emulator and host tests are not proof of safe saving on a physical Supercard. Back up your SD card and use disposable documents first.

Installation

- A GBA-compatible system and **Supercard SD** using the inherited SuperFW-compatible SD driver. Other flashcarts and generic emulator save files are not supported storage backends.
- Copy gbawriter.gba to your flashcart and launch it through its usual ROM loader. The source build produces the ROM; published builds belong under this repository's Releases.
- Documents live only in **/gbawriter/** on the SD card. The app attempts to create the directory when New/Load is first selected. An SD/directory error is displayed instead of discarding text.
- Menu and control instructions do not probe SD at boot. Choosing New/Load shows CHECKING SD...; an absent/incompatible card can take a substantial driver timeout to report an error. Emulator menu/help operation does not imply SD access works.
- Back up the SD card before testing. Never remove the card or power off while SAVING is displayed.

Diary and file workflow

New File is selected at startup. Press A to choose a date, then A to create and edit. The preset is exactly one calendar day after the chronologically latest valid diary filename, including month/year/leap-year transitions. Filenames use **DDMMYYYY.txt**; raw alphabetical order is not used to choose the latest date.

If no dated documents exist, the manual starting date is **10 July 2026**. This is an editable preset, not a real-time clock. In the date picker, Up/Down selects Day/Month/Year; Left decrements and Right increments the field; A creates; B returns. Invalid day combinations are clamped. Supported years are 1–9999. At the upper calendar boundary there is no representable next day: the picker retains the latest date, and creation still refuses a collision.

New File never overwrites an existing name, including case-only .TXT differences. A collision shows FILE ALREADY EXISTS and returns to the unchanged proposed date after acknowledgment. It does not add suffixes or truncate the original.

Load File lists .txt files in /gbawriter/: valid diary dates newest first, then other names alphabetically (ASCII case-insensitive). Up/Down selects; A opens; B returns. The display shows six entries at a time; the storage index rescans in bounded 32-entry batches, so the directory is not limited to 32 files. Longer directories take longer to rescan. There are no delete, rename, duplicate, or overwrite-from-menu actions.

Controller layout

Main-menu **SELECT** opens controls and **START** opens credits; **B** returns from either. The adjacent bottom hints read exactly Select: Controls and Start: Credits. Credits always open on the personal first page: Made by Halim Jarrar, (C) 2026, halim-jarrar.de, and monday@halim-jarrar.de, with no version or third-party credit mixed into that page. Left/Right cycles the two Credits pages; B returns from either. The second page has the gbawriter V3.0 title and credits the SuperFW software font renderer, UNSCII fonts (viznut.fi/unscii, inherited source marked GPL), and Unifont-derived Hangul blocks. Font notices remain in the source.

The suite home screen reads gbawriter and files: /gbawriter, with NEW FILE first/default and LOAD FILE second. The version appears only on the second Credits page, not on Home.

Menu interface text, help section headings and navigation hints use the 5x7 font from gbamp3 (black; key hints grey); the blue Butano font draws only the > cursor on the menu, date fields and file list. Numeric date values, text filenames, saving indications, controls body text and credits content retain the SuperFW-based writing font. Editor typography and status positions are unchanged.

Hold a direction, then press **B / A / R** to choose its **first / second / third** letter. Lowercase is the default.

Direction	Normal: B / A / R	Hold L: B / A / R
Up	a / b / c	d / e / f
Right	h / i / j	k / l / m
Down	n / o / p	q / r / s
Left	t / u / w	x / y / z

L is held, never toggled. Diagonals are not letter groups.

- Keep Right held and press R twice: the first j becomes **g**.
- Keep Left held and press R twice: the first w becomes **v**.
- Release the group between presses to type literal jj or ww. These transformations depend on the same continuous hold, **not timing**, and never substitute unrelated text.
- **A alone:** space. **B alone:** backspace one UTF-8 codepoint; no effect at the beginning. Hold either button alone to repeat: one immediate edit, first repeat after **24 frames**, then every **5 frames**, exactly matching START navigation. Adding any other button cancels edit repeat; releasing a chord's modifier does not start it. Release A/B and press it alone again to rearm. Letter/SELECT/save chords remain press-only.
- **START released alone:** newline. Holding it does not insert immediately.

Shift and Caps

From normal case, **release a short isolated R press to arm one-shot Shift**. Hold **R alone continuously for 48 frames** (twice the initial A-repeat delay; about 0.8 seconds at 60 Hz) to enable **Caps while still held**, once per hold. Any other button before the threshold cancels that hold; releasing the companion cannot restart it. Release R and start a fresh solo hold.

With **Shift or Caps already active**, another isolated R press—short or long—**clears the mode on release**. It cannot arm Shift or Caps again during the same hold. Shift applies to the next successfully inserted alphabetic character; digits, spaces and punctuation do not consume it.

With Caps on, one isolated R press/release turns Caps off without arming Shift. R inside a direction group remains the third-letter key and cannot toggle Caps. Shift/Caps applies to the international letters below; ß stays ß, never two letters. Rejected capacity-limited edits do not consume Shift. A failed save preserves Shift/Caps as well as the document.

The bottom status bar reads **filename → active letter group → Shift/Caps**. The filename starts at x=8 (128-pixel slot), the group at x=144 (32-pixel slot), and Shift/Caps at x=184 (48-pixel slot): hold Up to see abc, or ABC with Shift/Caps; all normal and held-L groups follow the same rule. Release the direction to clear it; diagonals and START navigation show no letter group. * marks unsaved changes. Transient messages occupy only the filename slot, leaving capitalization and group visible.

START commands

Hold START, then:

Button	Action
Left / Right	Move caret one UTF-8 codepoint
Up / Down	Move to the closest horizontal position in the adjacent visual row
L / R	Previous / next viewport page, maintaining a valid caret
A	Save the current file
B	Save, then return to the main menu only on success
SELECT	Toggle the bottom status bar / full-screen editor

Navigation repeats while held. Releasing START after a recognized command **does not add a newline**, even when saving fails. A save failure opens a clear error message and returns to the editor with text retained after acknowledgment. There is no discard shortcut or autosave.

SELECT: one provisional character

Press SELECT alone to insert **.** **immediately**. Keep SELECT held to change **that same character**; release to keep it. Exception: SELECT after an eligible continuously held letter chord converts the existing letter instead (see International letters). Cycling never appends additional characters.

While SELECT is held	Cycle
Up	. → 1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5 → 6 → 7 → 8 → 9 → 0 → 1 ...
Down	. → 0 → 9 → 8 → 7 → 6 → 5 → 4 → 3 → 2 → 1 → 0 ...
R, without a direction	. → , → ' → " → : → ! → ? → .
L, without a completed letter chord	Exact reverse common-punctuation cycle
Right	. → (→) → / → ; → @ → # → % → & → _ → + → = → - → .
Left	Exact reverse additional-symbol cycle

A completed letter chord takes priority over intermediate directional/punctuation changes. For example SELECT, then Up, then L, then A changes the same provisional **.** to 1 and then to é, not three characters. A complete L-layer chord similarly overrides the temporary SELECT+L punctuation step. Unsupported accent families leave the provisional glyph unchanged. **START+SELECT toggles the status bar in the editor only**, in either press order. It cancels only a newly inserted SELECT provisional character, restoring the original caret and dirty state. A converted existing letter stays accented; it is not deleted. The chord never types, saves, or adds a newline. It toggles once per hold and suppresses commands until both START and SELECT are released; other held buttons do not prevent rearming.

International letters

Accents work in either order: hold SELECT, then enter the normal letter combination; or enter a letter and keep its **exact single D-pad direction, L if used, and producing B/A/R button continuously held**, then press SELECT. That same letter changes to its first accented variant, keeping its case, without adding a period or another letter. There is no time limit, but releasing or changing the combination ends eligibility. Other extra buttons disqualify this letter-first gesture; diagonals are not letter groups. A letter with no accent variants stays unchanged in the letter-first order.

Example: hold L+UP and press A to type e; keep L+UP+A held and press SELECT to turn that same e into é. In the other order, hold SELECT, then L+UP and press A to produce é as one character. The held-L groups work in both orders too.

While SELECT and the same group remain held, **release and press the final B/A/R selector again** to cycle in the exact order below. Keep the direction and L layer (if used) held during cycling. Release SELECT to keep the current result. The letter-first result keeps the original letter's lowercase/Shift/Caps case, even after one-shot Shift was consumed.

Family	Lowercase cycle	Uppercase equivalents
A	á â ã ä å æ	Á Â Ã Ä Å Æ
C	ç ċ ċ	Ç Ć Ć
E	é è ê ë	É Ê Ë Ì
I	í î ï ð	Í Î Ï
N	ñ ñ	Ñ Ñ
O	ó ô õ ö ø œ	Ó Ô Õ Ö Ø Æ
S	ß š ś	Š Š Š
U	ü ú û û	Ü Ú Û Ü
Y	ý ŷ	Ý Ÿ
Z	ž ź ż	Ž Ž Ž

E/S/Y/Z use the held L layer; N/O/U are unmodified groups. Cycles wrap back to the first alternate. All 77 distinct required lowercase/uppercase glyphs are verified against the real font packs and renderer, including even/odd pixel addressing. Main-menu **SELECT** opens 20 control pages; Left/Right changes page; B returns. Help strings are checked for glyph coverage and screen width.

Storage and attribution

Files have no size limit: they stay on the SD card and only changes use RAM. Up to 64 KiB of typed text can be unsaved at once; when the bar shows BUFFER FULL - SAVE, save to continue (the text is kept). Saving a large file takes longer. Saves change only the opened TXT file; no permanent .sav or settings file is used. Temporary .gwt, .gwb and .gwi recovery files may remain after interrupted or failed saves. Do not delete them on the original card: back up the card and consult the README recovery instructions. There is no undo/redo, autosave or discard shortcut.

Made by Halim Jarrar · (C) 2026 · halim-jarrar.de · monday@halim-jarrar.de. Based on GBARReader, SuperFW, Butano, FatFS and miniz; credits and font/vendor notices remain in the source. Fonts: SuperFW software font renderer; UNSCII fonts (viznut.fi/unsicii, inherited source marked GPL); Unifont-derived Hangul blocks. Original font notices remain in references/superfw/res/fonts. Application source: GNU GPL v3. See LICENSE and README for full attribution.